

BEATLES, THE



JOHN LENNON PLAYED rhythm guitar, Paul McCartney played bass, George Harrison played lead guitar, and Ringo Starr played the drums. Together they formed The Beatles – the most famous and influential group in the history of popular music. Their songs dominated the 1960s, when people believed that music could change the world, and the songwriting skills of Lennon and McCartney have ensured that their music lives on. Their songs still influence many musicians today.

Live performances

The Beatles began by playing live in clubs in and around Liverpool, UK. Their lively performances were an exciting contrast to the staid and solid players who dominated popular music at the time. The Beatles' reputation was based on the songwriting abilities of John Lennon and Paul McCartney. At first they both wrote traditional rock and roll songs about friendship and love, but as the pair developed, their subjects became more varied.



The Beatles play a football stadium in the USA

Recording

In 1966 The Beatles stopped performing live, and spent more time in the studio. There they experimented with different instruments, such as string orchestras and sitars, and with new recording techniques. Their masterpiece, *Sgt. Pepper's Lonely Hearts Club Band*, took many months to produce and made use of techniques such as tape-splicing and multi-track recording.



Please Please Me



Sgt. Pepper's



George Martin

British producer George Martin (b.1926) produced almost all The Beatles' records, having accepted their first demonstration tapes at EMI in 1962. Martin was a record producer with a background in both classical and popular music. He helped The Beatles get the most out of the recording studio and the wide range of instruments used in their records, translating many of their ideas into polished musical form.



Early life

All four Beatles were born in the English port of Liverpool and played in various rock and roll groups in the late 1950s. In 1960–61 John, Paul, George, and drummer Pete Best played at the Star Club in the German port of Hamburg, which taught them much about live performance. Back in England, The Beatles played regularly at Liverpool's Cavern Club. In 1962 their manager, Brian Epstein (1934–67), replaced Best with Ringo Starr as drummer.



Beatlemania

In January 1964, "I Want To Hold Your Hand" reached the top of the American music charts. A new word, "Beatlemania", entered the language as thousands of screaming fans mobbed the group wherever they went. Within months, The Beatles were the biggest music group in the world.



Plates with pictures of The Beatles

Memorabilia

The Beatles were one of the first bands to be featured on a host of souvenirs and memorabilia. The four were immortalized on everything from mugs and T-shirts to buttons, badges, posters, and other souvenirs. Many fans bought everything that featured their four favourite musicians.



Toy guitar with pictures of The Beatles

The last albums

By 1969 the group was falling apart as conflicts grew between the four members and their musical interests took different directions. Their last albums to appear were *Abbey Road* (1969) and *Let It Be*, which was released in 1970 but recorded before *Abbey Road*. The Beatles disbanded later that year. All four continued their careers as solo musicians.



The Beatles recording tracks for *Let It Be*

THE BEATLES

- 1940 John Lennon and Richard Starkey (Ringo Starr) born.
- 1942 Paul McCartney born.
- 1943 George Harrison born.
- 1957 John and Paul form first group, The Quarrymen.
- 1962 First record with EMI; Ringo Starr joins as drummer.
- 1964 Beatles head charts in USA.
- 1967 *Sgt. Pepper's Lonely Hearts Club Band* released.
- 1970 *Let It Be* released; Beatles disband.
- 1980 John Lennon shot dead.
- 1997 Paul McCartney knighted.
- 2001 George Harrison dies.

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